



FOLKLORE FINDER

FIELD GUIDE SERIES

FIELD GUIDE No.1

BLACK DOGS

of Britain & Ireland

LEGENDS · SIGHTINGS · HISTORY · LOCATIONS



A companion to the Folklore Finder Atlas

Black Dogs of Britain & Ireland

Across the islands a great spectral hound haunts the lonely lane, the churchyard and the parish boundary — Black Shuck in East Anglia, the Barghest of the north, the Cù Sìth of the Highlands. Almost always larger than any living dog, with eyes like coals, it is most often an omen: to meet its gaze was said to foretell a death within the year.

Black dog apparitions are recorded across England, Wales, Scotland and Ireland under many local names, and folklorists have long noted the family resemblance between them despite the distances involved. Theories for the tradition's spread range from a shared Norse and Brythonic memory of guardian or psychopomp animals to the more mundane fact that lonely roads, churchyards and boundary paths were where travellers were most likely to frighten themselves after dark. Written accounts thicken from the 16th century onward, but the tradition's oral roots are almost certainly older than any surviving record.

WHAT'S INSIDE



Introduction

Origins and meaning of the theme.



Distribution Map

Where the legends are reported.



Legend Profiles

Individual stories from across the isles.



In the Field

A companion for your own searches.



History & Folklore

How the legends evolved over time.



Reading the Signs

How to know one when you meet it.



Places to Visit

Real locations linked to the legends.



Explorer's Checklist

Track the legends you've discovered.



12 PAGES

PDF format



PRINT READY

A4 optimised



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Keep forever

Where the legends are found

Every marker is a legend in this guide, placed where its story is rooted. Absence of a marker does not mean absence of a legend.



● Reported legend · 14 sites across Britain & Ireland

How to know one when you meet it

The tradition is remarkably consistent across the islands. These are the marks that recur — the grammar of the black dog.

Eyes like coals

Burning eyes — red, yellow, or 'the size of saucers' — are the surest mark. To meet that gaze was, in most tellings, to be marked for a death within the year.

Unnatural size

Larger than any living dog; 'big as a calf' is the phrase used from Norfolk to the Highlands. Sheer size is what sets the spectral hound apart from a stray.

Silence & vanishing

It makes little sound and leaves no track. It falls into step beside you, then is simply gone — most often at a boundary: a gate, a bridge, a stile.

Thresholds & crossroads

Black dogs keep to in-between places — parish bounds, old roads, lychgates and crossroads — the very ground where the living and the dead were thought to meet.

Chains & fire

A dragging chain, a reek of sulphur, or a body wreathed in flame mark the more demonic hounds, especially in the tales of the south-west.

Omen or guardian?

Not every black dog brings death. Some, like the church grim, guard consecrated ground; others walk a lone traveller safely home. Read the errand, not just the beast.

Barghest

YORKSHIRE



The Story

The Barghest is the monstrous black dog of northern England, most feared across Yorkshire, where its name was long used to warn and to frighten. It appears as a huge shaggy hound with great teeth and saucer-sized eyes that glow like coals, padding the lonely lanes and the old streets of cities such as York and Leeds. To see the Barghest, or to hear its howl, was widely held to be an omen of death — and in some tales it appeared before the passing of a notable person, followed by all the dogs of the district. It belongs to the great family of British 'black dogs' that includes Black Shuck of East Anglia and the Padfoot of the West Riding, spectral hounds whose appearance bridges the living world and the dead. The name may come from 'burh-ghest', town-ghost, or from older words for a goblin or a funeral bier. Whatever its derivation, the Barghest remains one of the most enduring supernatural beasts of the north of England.

"A monstrous black dog of northern folklore, often linked to lonely roads, churchyards, and death omens."

AT A GLANCE

REGION
Yorkshire

TYPE
Beast

ALSO KNOWN AS
—

MOTIFS
—

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/barghest

Black Dog of Bouley Bay

BOULEY BAY, JERSEY



The Story

The Black Dog of Bouley Bay is the spectral hound of Jersey — a huge black dog with eyes like saucers and a dragging chain, said to haunt the steep lanes and the wild north-coast bay of Bouley on dark and stormy nights. To meet it was an omen of misfortune or of coming storm, and islanders dreaded the rattle of its chain on the wind. It belongs to the same broad family as the black dogs of mainland Britain — Black Shuck, the Barghest — but is wholly Jersey's own. There is a sly local tradition, too, that the legend was deliberately encouraged — if not invented — by the island's smugglers, who found a man-eating phantom hound an excellent way to keep the curious and the law-abiding shut indoors and off the coastal paths while contraband moved by night. Whether genuine apparition or smugglers' ruse grown real in the telling, the Black Dog of Bouley Bay is the best-known ghost-beast of the Channel Islands.

“The Black Dog of Bouley Bay, or Lé Tchian du Bouôlay, is a Jersey storm hound said to haunt the cliffs above the bay.”

AT A GLANCE

REGION

Bouley Bay, Jersey

TYPE

Beast

ALSO KNOWN AS

—

MOTIFS

coast, haunting

READ THE FULL LEGEND

folklorefinder.uk/legends/black-dog-of-bouley-bay

Black Shuck

NORFOLK



The Story

Black Shuck — his name thought to derive from the Old English 'scucca', meaning demon — has prowled the lonely lanes, marshes and shingle of Norfolk and Suffolk for centuries. He is most often met on dark, storm-wracked nights: a dog the size of a calf, shaggy and black, with a single fiery eye or a pair of them glowing like coals. To meet his gaze, tradition holds, is to be marked for death within the twelvemonth. His most infamous appearance came on 4 August 1577, when a great black dog is said to have burst into the church at Bungay during a thunderstorm, running down the nave and killing two parishioners at prayer before bolting for Blythburgh, where he left scorch marks said to be visible on the north door to this day. The Reverend Abraham Fleming recorded the terror in a breathless pamphlet, and the beast has haunted the East Anglian imagination ever since.

“A spectral black dog with blazing eyes the size of saucers, said to roam the coastline and heathlands of East Anglia.”

AT A GLANCE

REGION
Norfolk

TYPE
Beast

ALSO KNOWN AS
Old Shuck, Shuck

MOTIFS
coast, church, death-omen,
haunting

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/black-shuck

LEGEND PROFILE

Church Grim

ENGLAND & SCANDINAVIA



The Story

The Church Grim is a guardian spirit of the churchyard in English and Scandinavian folklore, a being whose duty is to watch over the dead and protect the sacred ground from those who would defile it — thieves, witches, and above all the Devil. It most often appears as a large black dog, though it could take other forms, prowling the graveyard especially in foul weather and at night, and tolling the church bell at a death. Behind the Church Grim lies a dark old belief about consecration. It was held that the first body buried in a new churchyard must stand guard over all the rest, and so be doomed to a restless vigil instead of peaceful rest. To spare a human soul this fate, the custom arose of burying an animal — most commonly a black dog — alive in the foundations or the north side of a new graveyard when it was first consecrated, so that the beast's spirit, rather than a Christian's, would become the protecting Grim. The same grim logic of the foundation-sacrifice attached to churches themselves and to other buildings. The Church Grim is closely related to the wider British family of spectral black dogs — the Barghest, Black Shuck, Padfoot and their kin — but differs in its essentially protective role: where many phantom hounds are omens of doom, the Grim is a warden, a fierce but rightful keeper of holy ground. Sightings of a black dog about a church porch, or the sense of being watched among the graves, were long laid at its door.

"A guardian spirit said to haunt churchyards, often appearing as a black dog."

AT A GLANCE

REGION
England & Scandinavia

TYPE
Ghost

ALSO KNOWN AS
—

MOTIFS
spectral, church, guardian,
haunting

READ THE FULL LEGEND
folklorefinder.uk/legends/church-grim

Walk the ground the stories haunt



Black Dog of Bouley Bay

BOULEY BAY, JERSEY

The Black Dog of Bouley Bay, or Lé Tchian du Bouôlay, is a Jersey storm hound said to haunt the cliffs above the bay. Its glowing eyes, dragging chain and howls warned fishermen of bad weather; one tradition suggests smugglers encouraged the tale.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/black-dog-of-bouley-bay



Gwyllgi

NANT Y GARTH PASS, DENBIGHSHIRE, WALES

The Gwyllgi, the Dog of Darkness, is a great phantom black hound of Welsh folklore with blazing eyes and a shaggy pelt. Unlike the spectral pack of the Cŵn Annwn, it is a solitary creature of roads and hedgerows. A local tradition places it in the Nant y Garth Pass in the Clwydian Hills.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/gwyllgi



La Bête De La Tour

GUERNSEY, CHANNEL ISLANDS

La Bête De La Tour—'the Beast of the Tower'—is Guernsey's most feared phantom: a massive black dog wrapped in clanking chains with eyes like burning coals, whose very appearance was believed to foretell the viewer's death.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/la-bete-de-la-tour



Macphie and the Black Dog of Colonsay

COLONSAY, ARGYLL, SCOTLAND

A supernatural black dog appeared unbidden in the Laird of Colonsay's hunting boat and sailed with the party to Jura. When they sheltered in a cave that night, only Macphie emerged alive — dog, men, and answers all gone.

folklorefinder.uk/legends/macphie-and-the-black-dog-of-colonsay

EXPLORER TIP

Many sites are wild, remote or private. Stay safe, respect the land and follow local guidance.

Dusk and the dead of night, and most of all the turning points of the year — the old fire-festivals, and the nights around a funeral or a storm.

Lonely lanes and green roads, lychgates and churchyards, parish boundaries, bridges and the coast path.
Black dogs keep to edges.

The eyes, the size, the sound (or silence), and where it appears and vanishes. Mark the exact spot — the tradition is rooted in real places.

Never trespass; ask permission on private land. Don't go alone after dark, tell someone your route, and leave every site as you found it.

Date · Place · What you saw

How the legends took shape

Black dog apparitions are recorded across England, Wales, Scotland and Ireland under many local names, and folklorists have long noted the family resemblance between them despite the distances involved. Theories for the tradition's spread range from a shared Norse and Brythonic memory of guardian or psychopomp animals to the more mundane fact that lonely roads, churchyards and boundary paths were where travellers were most likely to frighten themselves after dark. Written accounts thicken from the 16th century onward, but the tradition's oral roots are almost certainly older than any surviving record.

SIMILAR CREATURES

Black dogs shade into a wider family of spectral hounds and guardian beasts — the barghest of the north, the Manx moddey dhoo, the Welsh gwyllgi, the church grim set to guard consecrated ground, and the Cù Sith of the Highlands. Most share the same core: a great black dog, burning eyes, and an errand between this world and the next.

EXPLORER'S CHECKLIST

Track your discoveries

Tick off each legend as you track it down.

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Barghest <i>Yorkshire</i> | ☐ Macphie and the Black Dog of Colonsay |
| ☐ Black Dog of Bouley Bay <i>Bouley Bay</i> | ☐ Moddey Dhoo <i>Peel Castle</i> |
| ☐ Black Shuck <i>Norfolk</i> | ☐ Padfoot <i>Yorkshire</i> |
| ☐ Church Grim <i>England & Scandinavia</i> | ☐ Tchico <i>Guernsey</i> |
| ☐ Dando's Dogs <i>Cornwall</i> | ☐ The Black Dog of Newgate <i>London</i> |
| ☐ Gwyllgi <i>Nant y Garth Pass</i> | ☐ The Girt Dog of Ennerdale <i>Ennerdale</i> |
| ☐ La Bête De La Tour <i>Guernsey</i> | ☐ Tyrell's Hound <i>New Forest</i> |



ABOUT THE SERIES

The Folklore Finder Field Guide Series explores the creatures, places and people of British and Irish folklore — one theme at a time. Each guide is a companion to the interactive atlas at folklorefinder.uk.

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